

To release any final product, one needs to follow a process, and game development is no exception, and there are three distinct phases in the process. These are very similar to the ones followed in software development life cycles (SDLC). There's this waterfall model, which is rarely followed. The most common model followed is the Iterative with Rapid Prototype model. In the Iterative Design with Rapid Prototype model, designers focus on game-play over graphics. Many game designers prefer paper prototyping of video games as it is easier to test iteratively. Once the prototyping is done, play-test takes place. This might be a full or partial play session to identify strengths and weaknesses in designs. Then, corresponding changes are made to the design depending upon the reviews after the play-test and this process is repeated iteratively.

The game development process is broken down into four phases:

1. Pre-Production
2. Production
3. Post-Production
4. The Aftermath

In this chapter, we will see how a game is developed and what activities are conducted during these phases so as to get a clear and solid understanding of game development process.

1. Pre-Production

This is also known as the design phase. In this phase, the main outline of the game, planning, scheduling and documentation is done. This phase is very important to pitch a game to the publishers. This phase is not funded by publishers.

Before understanding the design process, one needs to know what game-play and game-mechanics mean. These are known as the atomic elements of game design.

Players, avatars and game bits

In majority of the digital and non-digital games, players are represented either by an avatar or game-bits like many RPGs, FPS, Monopoly. In some of the games, the player has no avatar and the player represents himself or herself. This is true in case of games such as *Poker* or *Risk*; where little soldiers and artillery pieces are defending the player – the unseen leader. It is very important in a game to define this part.